

How To Improve Your English Pronunciation



Table of Contents

The Reasons

Why would anyone want to change their accent? 3

The Benefits

What are the main benefits of adapting your accent? 5

The Difficulties

Why is adapting your accent difficult? 10

The Techniques

What techniques can I use to help adapt my accent? 14

The Results

Boost your career through accent training 23

The Reasons

Why would anyone want to change their accent?

We are driven by the need to be understood.

Firstly, there is nothing wrong with having a unique accent. There are many different varieties of spoken English all over the world, and each one has its own unique flavor. There is no better or worse and people should embrace language diversity as a positive.

That being said - what's defined as standard English is largely done so by the English-speaking business community. For the most part, this includes American, British and Australian English. So if you work in an environment where one of these varieties is the primary spoken language, you may want to adapt the way you speak. But why?

Native speakers may find you difficult to understand. **In a business context, this can lead to problems.** Both internal and external business communication can suffer. This can also make you feel self-conscious, discouraged or even like an outsider.

And while you might think that how you speak is something you can't change, you can!

In fact, as an English learner, your accent has been constantly changing since you started learning English. As you get better, you naturally start to assimilate sounds differently. Even native speakers change the way they speak. Wait what? Yes, that's right. If a British person goes to America and stays there a while, quite often they pick up traces of an American accent. This can even happen subconsciously.

This happens because we are driven by the need to be understood. So accent modification is responding to this need.

This guide is not trying to change your identity. The mission of this guide is to make you speak more clearly in a business context. And as you'll see, improving your pronunciation has a host of powerful benefits that can help you take your career to the next level.

The Benefits

What are the main benefits of adapting my accent?

We spoke to some of our top students at global companies to learn more about the main benefits they have experienced through accent adaptation.

Here are some of the most powerful benefits you could gain by adapting your accent:



"I don't feel as much native speaker bias anymore"

Unfortunately, native speaker bias is a real thing. Native speaker bias (also called **accent bias**) is where your work colleagues subconsciously give preference to other employees who talk like they do.

This can occur for several different reasons, including finding their native speaker colleagues easier to understand. But what's important are the effects of this bias. By counteracting native speaker bias, you will be treated as an equal by your native speaker colleagues.

This means more acceptance and more chance of internal promotion when HR conducts performance reviews.

"I speak more clearly and don't have to repeat myself"

Clarity is one of the main benefits of working on your accent. And in a way, most benefits are related to you being able to speak more clearly.

Through the act of training your accent, you are reducing the number of sounds that make your accent different from that of a native speaker. When a native speaker notices a sound that they wouldn't expect, in a phrase or sentence, or even a different type of intonation or melody, this triggers a response in the brain.

This confusion makes it much harder for them to focus on what you are saying. You'll find this often leads to them asking you to repeat yourself which can be frustrating. It can also slow your progress at work.



"People ask me where I'm from a lot less now"

Are you tired of people asking: "So where do you come from?"

By working on your accent people focus their questions on your interests rather than fixate on your linguistic background. This is great motivation to keep working on your accent.



"I feel more included at work"

No matter how inclusive your company is, your accent can make you feel self-conscious and like a bit of an outsider.

This can be related to accent bias and can even happen subconsciously. Our accent is one of the things that creates social cohesion.

So by adapting to your linguistic surroundings this naturally leads to more inclusion.

"My colleagues and clients understand me a lot better now."

In all areas of business, communication is essential. So being better understood by your colleagues will lead to **improved performance at your work.**

Furthermore, it will improve your managers' perception of your performance. Sounding more like a native speaker will lead to **better feedback from clients and users, too.**

"I feel more confident when speaking"

Believe it or not, **working on your accent can be one of the best ways to unlock confidence.**

It can be overwhelming to learn a new language, particularly when it's important for your career. But by actively training your accent, you will elicit positive responses from your conversational partners.

This, in turn, encourages you to keep learning. Also, by speaking clearly, you can be sure that what you learn will be understood

"I was able to land my dream job"

All of the benefits above **increase the chance of you getting a promotion or even landing your dream job.**

Speaking clearly and confidently may just get you that dream interview you've been waiting for.

The Difficulties

Why is adapting your accent difficult?

Now, that we have seen the benefits of training your accent, let's identify why you might feel changing your accent is difficult. We work with students from very different linguistic backgrounds.

Our mission is to help them overcome any language hurdle that stands between them and their goals. When it comes to accent reduction, the following are the main challenges our students face.

Do any of these feel familiar?

"I don't have enough time"

One of the most common problems is time. Many of our students are very busy in their working lives, so Talaera works on quick and effective language solutions.

But the problem is, by not investing a little time in adapting your accent, you may be worsening your career prospects.

"My colleagues don't understand me very well"

Depending on your working context, your colleagues may find your accent difficult to understand. This can lead to other negative effects such as feeling like an outsider, not part of the community or even being viewed as less competent than others.

This may leave you feeling too self-conscious to practice in front of your colleagues, making it harder to improve.



"It seems impossible"

"I can't change the way I sound" - We have heard this many times before. It is a commonly held belief that you can't change the way you sound. This is not true.

As you progress as a speaker, you naturally begin to lose elements of your foreign accent and speak more clearly as your ear picks up native speaker sounds. You can speed up the process with targeted practice and training.

"I don't know how to link words together and sound natural"

Languages are like a piece of music. It's not just the notes that matter, but also the spaces in between. How you pronounce or link words together affects the overall melody of your accent.

"I don't want to change who I am"

Some people feel that changing their accent is somehow changing who they are as a person or their identity. We encourage you to reframe this view. In a business context, you need to be understood.

The bottom line is if you're colleagues find you hard to understand, you will be less effective at work. We also understand that changing your accent may make you feel self-conscious. But this doesn't mean you can't still talk in your preferred dialect or with an accent with family and friends.

But by having the ability to change your accent, you are adding another important business skill to your toolbox.

"I can't find any good information to help me"

Most resources out there are quite generic. That means they are not suited to adapting your unique accent because they were designed for group classes. However, to truly be effective you need information that is tailored to your needs.

“I don’t know why I sound different”

One of the main reasons people find it so difficult to improve their accent is they don’t know what sounds or difference they have compared to a native speaker.

But this is an essential starting point for improving your accent.

“My teachers are non-native”

We are sure that you’ve had great English teachers, but often they may have been non-native speakers themselves.

This is not a bad thing in itself. But it does mean that you did not have contact with the native speaker sounds you need to hear. To truly adapt your accent, native speaker teachers are essential, because contact with the target sounds improves your ability to make these sounds yourself.

“I don’t know how to make that sound”

Another common problem is not being able to produce a particular sound.

For example, you may know that you find the /r/ sound is difficult for you, but no matter how hard you try you cannot find a way to make that sound. This is a key barrier in adapting your accent.



Fortunately, we have come up with simple solutions to all of these problems. Read on to learn how to clear these pronunciation hurdles...

The Techniques

What techniques can I use to help adapt my accent?

Talaera specializes in helping business students achieve their language goals. Over thousands of hours of sessions, we have developed some great techniques to help modify your accent - and here are some quick and simple strategies to get you started:

#1 Record yourself frequently

Once you have identified your problem sounds, you should record yourself while practicing them. This is an effective strategy because you can compare your pronunciation to the target sound. Why not try with some of the videos above? Pick a sound you find tricky and listen to how it should sound. Now, record your attempts at saying it out loud. Do you notice any difference? Keeping track of your progress will allow you to improve quicker.

#2 Focus on speaking, not reading

This is more of a general tip. Yes, it's important to read, but for most learners, it's a lot easier to mimic a sound than manually learning complicated pronunciation rules. Use every opportunity you have to try speaking with other speakers. You can try chatting with colleagues from work, or if that's intimidating you could attend a local language meetup. Speaking will build your confidence quickly and give you a better intuition for the correct pronunciation.

And remember: When you learn a new word, always listen to the pronunciation. Most online dictionaries have an audio feature. Repeat the word out loud 5-10 times as you learn it.

#3 Identify your problem sounds

The first step is to identify your problem sounds. Each speaker is different but there are some trends depending on the region you come from.

Check out these videos to get started pronouncing ten of the most difficult sounds in the English language. Keep track of the sounds you find difficult and try practicing them for a couple of minutes each day.

1) L and R are often mixed together by East Asian English speakers

Let's get our tongues involved! "L" is one of the easier letters to perfect because it sounds the same when it appears at the beginning of a word as well as within in one.

When making the "L" sound ([l]) you need to briefly touch your tongue to the bottom of your top two front teeth and then let the tongue linger outside the mouth for a moment. Your mouth needs to remain slightly open in order to accommodate the tongue sticking out.



The English "R" is notably different from its Spanish counterpart. While the Spanish "R" utilizes a rolling of the tongue, the English "R" only vibrates through the throat. To make the "R" sound ([r]) begin by closing your teeth, opening your lips, and make a growling sound like an angry dog ready to attack, "Errrr." As you make this sound, lightly place a finger where your Adam's apple is or would be. You should feel a vibration.



Practice the |l| and |r| sounds:
light - right
alive - arrive
long - wrong

2) W and V are often used interchangeably by German and Indian English speakers

“W” typically makes a “wuh” sound. To create this sound (|w|), pucker your lips together as though you were about to kiss someone. Now, instead of making the exaggerated kiss sound of “mwah”, just skip over the “m.” You’ll notice that you need to release the pucker, or rounding, of the lips immediately.



Practice the |w| sound:
would - want - will - water

To make the “V” sound (|v|), allow your upper front teeth to connect with the inside of your front lower lip. Now try vibrating the top teeth against the bottom lip. Your tongue needs to remain immobile in its place so it doesn’t interrupt the vibration.



Practice the |v| and |w| sounds:
very well - very wet - very white

3) T and D are often confused by Indian English speakers

The main difference here lies in where the tongue is located in the mouth.

The “T” sound ([t]) is made by tapping the tip of the tongue behind the top front teeth. When practicing the “T” sound it should have an aspirated quality, you should hear the puff of your breath.



The “D” sound ([d]) is created when the tip of the tongue hits much further back on the roof of the mouth.



Practice the [t] and [d] sounds:
ten - den
tip - dip
town - down

4) French and Israeli English speakers especially seem to struggle with the hard “H” sound

“H” is a challenging sound ([h]) to create for many English learners because it doesn’t exist in some Romance languages.

To create the “H” sound, begin in front of a mirror. Bringing your open mouth close to the glass, sharply exhale through the mouth and try to produce a “huh” sound. Your tongue should remain immobile and in place and you should fog up the glass with your sharp exhalation. You may even be able to feel the contraction of your diaphragm as you exhale sharply to create this sound.



Practice the |h| sound:
home - hard - help - hat

5) “Th” is often considered the most difficult sound to produce for non-native speakers

The “th” sound (|θ|) often comes out as more of an “s”, leading non-native speakers to say “sink” instead of “think.”

To properly create the “th” sound, represented with |θ|, you need to leave a tongue-sized space between top and bottom teeth and then, as you exhale through the mouth, close the gap in your teeth with your tongue and let the tongue protrude from the mouth. Yes, you must stick your tongue out to properly create this sound!



Practice the |θ| sound with this tongue twister - say it as fast as possible without mispronouncing words.:

“Thrust three thousand thistles through the thick of his thumb.”

6) The suffixes “-ing” and “-ink”

When spoken, the suffix “-ing” (|ɪŋ|) is often overexaggerated, adding a “guh” sound to the end so it sounds more like “singuh” instead of “sing.” Additionally, the ending “-ink” is frequently pronounced when it should be “-ing.”

To create the nasal “-ing” sound ([ɪŋ]), lift your tongue so the back of the tongue is touching the roof of the mouth. The front of the tongue does not make contact with any other part of the mouth. You may notice that the noise is actually being released through the nose.

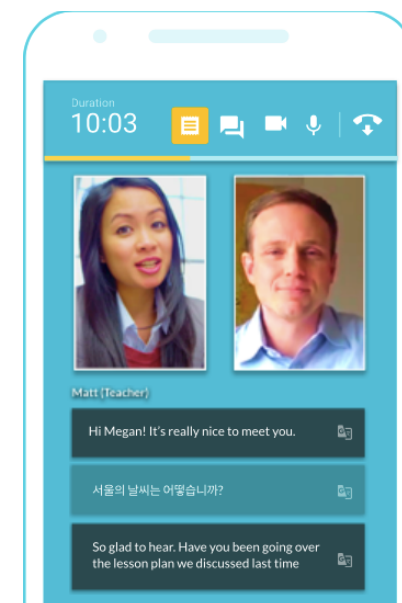


To produce the “K” in “-ink” ([ɪŋk]) the back of the tongue will briefly connect with the roof of the mouth but it will pull away quickly and produce an aspirated sound as it releases. Think of the back of the tongue as suctioning to the roof of the mouth, closing off the throat. As you rip the suction away, you create the hard “K.”

Practice these sounds:
thing - think
wing - wink
sing - sink



You can now practice these strategies with an expert teacher. [Learn more!](#)



#4 Try and learn phrases rather than words

Each phrase has a melody, like a piece of music. This melody is important because it is how native speakers decode what you're saying.

While there are pronunciation guides out there that teach you techniques to find the stressed syllable, one quick and easy way to improve your melody is to learn whole phrases rather than words. This way you learn the words in context and how they should be pronounced together.

Again, podcasts are great for this. Take your favorite podcast in an area you're interested in. You'll notice very quickly that there are 5 or 10 phrases that the guests and hosts say a lot. And if you can't find an audio example of the phrase you want to learn, maybe you can get a friend to record it for you!

#5 Audio shadowing

This next technique may seem a little strange at first. Take your favorite podcast or radio show and try repeating a portion of the audio. Your goal is to mimic the speaker. Believe it or not, this will help your pronunciation, intonation, and melody over time. It will also help train your ear to pick out different sounds. It's also a really quick exercise to do.



#6 Practice linking words

This is perhaps one of the most overlooked parts of improving pronunciation. You may learn a bunch of new words, but do you know how to say them together? Native speakers remove or even change the pronunciation of words when they say them together. But don't worry, with a little training, this will seem natural to you as well. Check out the video below to see what we mean:



#7 Get help from the experts

Investing in accent training pays off, and companies know it. Employees at over 65 companies are already enjoying Talaera's custom English accent training for tech professionals.

We focus on communication ability. Talaera enables you to communicate with colleagues and focus on real-life problems: big picture stuff. And the best part is, you don't even have to pay for it yourself. Win-win!

So why not tell your talent manager to add English training to the list of personal development opportunities? If they need some convincing, share this ebook with them.

**Start Improving
Your Accent**

The Results

Boost your career through accent training

Learn more about our customized accent and language training.

Hopefully, you found this guide useful.

We saw that working on your accent has a whole host of benefits, including increased language confidence, improved communication and even increased chances of landing your dream job.

Through dedicated learning, you can adapt to your linguistic environment and be better understood by your native speaker colleagues and clients.

So what are you waiting for? Start working on your accent today.

But to truly take your accent training to the next level, why not partner with the best in the business?

Let your talent manager know that you are interested in this training, or let us know and we'll get in touch with them.

Talaera: Business English Communications Training



Learn more





<https://talaera.com>

